🗳️ Women's Suffrage: Reading

US History · Unit 8 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Suffrage Pre-Quiz, American Suffragists notes, Mom Did You Vote?, cartoons, Iron Jawed Angels

Name: _____

Winning the Vote

In 1848 Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Lucretia Mott organized the first women's rights convention at Seneca Falls, New York. Their Declaration of Sentiments, modeled on the Declaration of Independence, declared that “all men and women are created equal” and demanded suffrage, the right to vote. Many people, including some supporters, thought the demand was too radical.

Susan B. Anthony became the movement's best-known leader. In 1872 she voted in the presidential election in Rochester and was arrested. At her trial the judge fined her $100; she replied that she would “never pay a dollar of your unjust penalty,” and she never did. Western territories such as Wyoming (1869) and Washington (1910) gave women the vote before most eastern states.

By the 1910s the movement split over strategy. The National American Woman Suffrage Association (NAWSA), led by Carrie Chapman Catt, worked patiently state by state. Alice Paul and Lucy Burns formed the National Woman's Party (NWP), which demanded a federal amendment and used bold public protest. On March 3, 1913, the day before Woodrow Wilson's inauguration, Paul organized a parade of more than 5,000 marchers led by Inez Milholland on a white horse. Hostile crowds attacked the marchers. Black suffragists were told to march at the back; Ida B. Wells refused.

In 1917 the NWP's “Silent Sentinels” picketed the White House daily. While the US fought a war “to make the world safe for democracy,” one banner called the president “Kaiser Wilson.” Police arrested the picketers for “obstructing traffic.” At the Occoquan Workhouse they were beaten, and Alice Paul's hunger strike led to force-feeding. Newspaper stories about this treatment won the movement public sympathy.

Women's war work and the pressure of both organizations finally moved Wilson to support suffrage in 1918. Congress passed the 19th Amendment in 1919. On August 18, 1920, Tennessee became the 36th state to ratify when 24-year-old legislator Harry Burn changed his vote after his mother wrote, “Be a good boy” and vote yes. Still, poll taxes, literacy tests and citizenship rules kept many Black, Native American and Asian American women from voting for decades.

Check your reading

1. Compare NAWSA's and the NWP's strategies.

2. Why did the Silent Sentinels call the president “Kaiser Wilson”?

3. Which women still could not vote after 1920, and why?